

ENG 1005 · Grammar Cheat Sheet (One Page)

Quick reference for the Grammar & Mechanics Exam

Topic	Rule in one line	Example
Independent clause	Complete thought, stands alone.	<i>The butler vanished.</i>
Subordinate clause	Starts with <i>because/although/when/which</i> ; can't stand alone.	<i>Although the alibi seemed airtight...</i>
Fragment	A piece missing a subject, verb, or complete thought — attach or complete it.	<i>X Hiding in the shadows.</i> → ✓ <i>The killer was hiding in the shadows.</i>
Comma splice	Two sentences joined by only a comma — add a conjunction, semicolon, or period.	<i>X The lights went out, no one screamed.</i> → ✓ <i>...out, but no one screamed.</i>
Run-on / fused	Two sentences with no punctuation — separate them.	<i>X The clock struck twelve the body was found.</i> → ✓ <i>When the clock struck twelve, the body was found.</i>
Comma: intro	Comma after an opening phrase/clause.	<i>After the storm passed, they returned.</i>
Comma: series	Commas between items, including before <i>and</i> .	<i>a ticket, a watch, and a glove</i>
Comma: extra info	Pair of commas around non-essential info.	<i>Christie, who wrote the novel, ...</i>
Semicolon (;)	Joins two complete, related sentences.	<i>The evidence was clear; the jury agreed.</i>
Colon (:)	Complete sentence + list or explanation.	<i>One rule: never trust a calm witness.</i>
Coordination	Equal ideas: comma + <i>and/but/or/so/yet</i> .	<i>The alarm failed, so he slipped in.</i>
Subordination	Unequal ideas: <i>although/because/when/which</i> .	<i>Although it was locked, he got in.</i>
Parallelism	List items share the same form.	<i>clever, observant, and cautious</i>
Dangling modifier	Opening phrase must describe the next word.	<i>X Covered in dust, the detective found it.</i> → ✓ <i>...found the diary, which was covered in dust.</i>
Misplaced modifier	Put the modifier next to what it describes.	✓ <i>We solved almost every clue.</i> (not <i>almost solved</i>)
Agreement	<i>Each/every/everyone/neither</i> = singular.	<i>Each suspect has an alibi.</i>
Collective noun	<i>Jury/team</i> = singular.	<i>The jury reached its verdict.</i>
Pronoun case	After a preposition use <i>me/him/her/them</i> .	<i>Between you and me...</i>

Three-second checks

- **Splice/run-on?** Could a period replace the comma (or the gap)? → fix it.
- **Colon?** Is there a complete sentence *before* it? → required.
- **Parallel?** Do the listed items all start with the same kind of word? → they should.
- **Pronoun?** Drop the other person: "to *me*" sounds right, "to *I*" doesn't.

Practice exam → <https://regimurray.github.io/English1005/>